Ever



heard the sound of the glass ceiling breaking? Perhaps not. Because women accomplish that feat like they do everything else—with a quiet fortitude. Patience is a virtue they come naturally endowed with, so that when the time comes, they can wear any mantle with ease.

That time has come. Women in India are becoming a rising force. Politically, their franchise is beginning to matter. Female voting percentages have been going up steadily in the country's elections, be it to the Lok Sabha or to the lower houses of the state. Their turnout in the 2019 general election was 67.2 per cent, for the first time a few percentage points higher than for men. Political parties have, in fact, been quick to recognise the power of the woman voter and begun wooing them assiduously, the Gruha Lakshmis and the Ladli Behnas. Giving them free cylinders, and bus rides, even dedicating Swachh Bharat and Har Ghar Nal Se Jal to them.

Why, this September, they even gave them a Women's Reservation Bill, keeping aside a third of the seats in the central and state legislatures for them.

Give a woman something, and she makes it only greater. Give her a say, and see where it takes her. India's grassroots governance is already witness to the possibilities, with 50 per cent of the seats in panchayats and urban local bodies reserved for women. In Jambur village in Gujarat's Junagadh district, the now 70-year-old Hirbai Ibrahim Lobi has liberated the women of her Siddi tribe by teaching them simple financial literacy. As Meena Kandasamy, an anti-caste activist, poet, novelist and translator, puts it:

Sometimes,
the outward signals
of inward struggles take colossal forms
And the revolution happens because
our dreams explode

In a country where they still form only 14 per cent of the total legislators in the Lok Sabha, women could use a little affirmative action to gain some political muscle. Or rely on extraordinary zeal.

Of the Mamata Banerjee kind. The diminutive she-David who has made a habit of slaying Goliaths. If, in 2011, she vanquished the Communist Party's hold over the state for nearly a third of a century, in 2021, she brought the saffron juggernaut to a grinding halt with a broken foot. And yet, she is humble enough to say, "I am an LIP (less important person), not a VIP." West of Bengal, Mayawati remains an icon in retreat, but is still the only Dalit chief minister to have served four terms and leave an indelible mark on the politics of her state. The charge of the Indian Republic is vested with Droupadi Murmu, India's first woman president from the tribal community. The country's financial reins, meanwhile, are in the hands of another redoubtable personality—the no-nonsense finance minister of India, Nirmala Sitharaman—who steers the nation's purse strings with equal felicity as she does the prime minister's vision.

She may not have adequate representation yet, but the woman in India is using her franchise to assert her political might

Change is afoot in realms economic as well. The financing operation of

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**